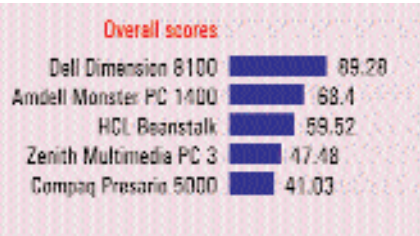


Give me all!

The third set of PCs tested were in the price category of Rs 50,001 and above. For a price range such as this, you should expect high-performance systems. In fact, this range of PCs would appeal to users who are purely interested in the best in performance and features, and sometimes, simply the brand. Cost is not a criterion for them.



Performance systems: scorers in the Content Creation test

These PCs are chosen by hardcore professionals who need maximum computing power when it comes to demanding applications as seen in video and audio processing, graphics and animation. With the current configurations, the PCs that would fit this category would require at least Pentium 4 1.4 GHz and above or AMD Athlon 1.2 GHz with 256 MB of RAM, 7200-rpm 40-GB hard drive with a GeForce-class graphics card. Along with this, these users also would look at peripherals such as DVD or CD-RW drives.

We received only five PCs in this category. With Pentium 4 as well as Athlon processor-based PCs easily available for under Rs 50,000, it was the extra bundling of peripherals that made the difference in this category. Intel once again dominated in this segment and four out of five PCs were based on its processors (three were P4s and one was a P-III).

Dell, which is the new entrant in the comparison tests this year, dominated in the tests involving the graphics processor, primarily due to the fact that it came along with a GeForce3 having 64 MB DDR RAM onboard. For gamers this is the ultimate machine as the *Quake III* test results would indicate—it delivered a stunning 193.7 fps and 189 fps in normal and high quality, respectively. Although audio encoding was not the fastest, it was still able to complete the encoding within 34 seconds, next only to Amdell's score of 24 seconds. With an exotic choice of components like 12x/8x/32x CD-RW and a NEC DVD-ROM drive, along with Turtle Beach Santacruz 5.1 soundcard, the Dell Dimension 8100 boasted of a set of

peripherals that could make any neighbour envious! This PC sported a duo-tone black and silver colour, making it stand apart from its rivals not only in performance and price but also in looks. Also, this is the only PC that is completely configurable on the company's Web site with a host of different hardware configurations—at varying prices according to components chosen, of course.

The second-best PC in this premium segment was the Amdell Monster PC 1400. Housing the formidable Athlon 1.4 GHz processor with 128 MB DDR RAM, it gave fantastic scores in Adobe Photoshop (in fact, the best in this category) of 104.93 seconds that is nearly half compared to the second best of Dell that took 210.07 seconds. This indicates that users requiring PC for data-intensive applications should definitely give a fair chance to this PC. Although in *Quake III* it scored 77.1 fps and 25.3 fps, respectively, in normal and high settings, which from an avid gamer's point of view is definitely not enough, casual gamers shouldn't be complaining. Furthermore, with the DVD and a creative Vibra 128 soundcard, it can double up as a good infotainment PC.

The HCL Beanstalk Omega is a also a good choice. Although it did not do very well in the test (Content Creation Winstone 2000 generated only 32.4) it had some good choice of components such as the Pioneer 16x DVD, ASUS P4T-M motherboard and the Yamaha soundcard. The only bottleneck was in the graphics subsystem with a GeForce2 MX 400, which generated 35.8 and 19.6 fps in *Quake III*, respectively, for normal and high settings.

Zenith's PC in this category had a base

configuration that most users might look for, but the graphics subsystem used was way under par and both the games test of *Quake III* and *Evolva* failed. The only bright spot in this PC was the Creative 12x DVD. You could consider this system if you are looking at pure processor power, but it may not be the best choice available in terms of overall value.

CONCLUSION

In this roundup of branded PCs, we've seen a very wide variation on a number of grounds such as features available, platforms, designs and performance. Each of these three categories exhibited very close competition, especially in terms of features versus prices. With the cost of hardware spiralling downwards continually, even the casual home user can now afford a gigahertz-based computer. Couple this with the fast hard drives and graphics accelerators and you have power in your living room, power which was once within the reach of



Nebula Qmax Triad: good performance at an attractive price

